



Paul <paulrekaris@gmail.com>

COVID-19 vaccine safety monitoring commitments – request for committee scrutiny

2 messages

Paul <paulrekaris@gmail.com>

16 December 2025 at 09:24

To: senator.cox@aph.gov.au

Cc: senator.allman-payne@aph.gov.au, "Antic, Alex (Senator)" <senator.antic@aph.gov.au>, community.affairs.sen@aph.gov.au

Bcc: Paul <paulrekaris@gmail.com>

Dear Senator Cox,

At the Community Affairs Legislation Committee's 9 October 2025 estimates hearing, senior TGA officials described COVID-19 vaccine safety monitoring as being managed through the agency's "day-to-day pharmacovigilance processes" during the TGA's COVID-19 Vaccine Safety Monitoring Plan. Officials were unable to point to any systematic tracking of implementation against the Plan's stated objectives. This characterisation appears difficult to reconcile with the "enhanced" monitoring that was a legal condition of the provisional approval of these vaccines, and with National Cabinet's commitment to active and comprehensive post-market safety monitoring in the [Australian COVID-19 Vaccination Policy](#).

For clarity, this correspondence does not suggest that safety monitoring activities did not occur. Rather, it concerns the absence of verifiable, systematic documentation demonstrating that the COVID-19 Vaccine Safety Monitoring Plan was implemented as a discrete, enhanced framework, as distinct from routine pharmacovigilance activities.

In an October 2021 pharmacovigilance presentation, TGA presented the COVID-19 Vaccine Safety Monitoring Plan (slide 23) as the overarching pharmacovigilance framework aiming to "enhance rapid detection, investigation and response" through five defined key strategies, detailing structured workflows, databases, communication processes and the Adverse Event Management System. This presentation, used to educate future pharmacy professionals on how the system operated, depicts a formal, documented program – a depiction fundamentally at odds with the October 2025 Senate testimony describing enhanced pharmacovigilance as day-to-day processes. The presentation is publicly available at: <https://www.tga.gov.au/sites/default/files/webinar-presentation-pharmacovigilance-regulators-perspective.pdf> and is attached in this email (**please note copyright notice**).

Subsequently, in decision AICmr54, the Office of the Australian Information Commissioner accepted that TGA could not identify any discrete implementation report for the Safety Monitoring Plan, after OAIC-directed MR22/00538 searches across more than 531 TRIM containers and over 2,200 sampled pages located no Plan-specific implementation or governance records. A later FOI request (25-0166) separately identified 399 Plan-aligned documents using standard classifications (SOPs, protocols, workflows, implementation guidelines), but TGA declined to

process them in full, relying on a practical-refusal decision under the Freedom of Information Act 1982 (Cth).

Taken together, the Oaic finding and the 9 October evidence indicate a serious and documented gap between Cabinet-endorsed safety monitoring commitments, the TGA's published Plan, and the evidence required to demonstrate that enhanced monitoring was delivered. This gap pertains to the oversight of approximately 68 million doses administered under provisional approval (around 94% of Australia's COVID-19 vaccine rollout).

This documentation gap stands in stark contrast to the structured governance framework established for the rollout itself. The [Commonwealth–State implementation plans](#), signed in February 2021 concurrently with the TGA's Safety Monitoring Plan, created formal governance structures requiring documented procedures, structured data reporting, and Statements of Assurance under the National Partnership on COVID-19 Response. These arrangements anticipated systematic implementation, defined data flows, and clear escalation pathways for safety-critical issues—not the undocumented, "day-to-day processes" described in recent TGA Senate testimony.

For ease of reference, I have prepared an open-source audit of the Safety Monitoring Plan that summarises the key issues and evidence, including an FAQ addressing common questions about this documentation and implementation gap:

GitHub Repository & FAQ: <https://github.com/paulrekaris/TGA-COVID19-Vaccine-Safety-Monitoring-Audit/blob/main/FAQ.md>

Under the Senate's standing orders, the Committee may examine the performance of departments and agencies. In that context, I am providing this material to assist the Committee in deciding whether further scrutiny is warranted regarding how the TGA and the Department implemented and documented these Cabinet-endorsed safety monitoring commitments.

If the Committee considers further examination appropriate, I respectfully suggest it might consider terms of reference for an inquiry, to examine:

1. Whether the Department of Health and Aged Care and the TGA complied with Commonwealth record-keeping, transparency and accountability obligations in implementing the COVID-19 Vaccine Safety Monitoring Plan within the established multi-tier governance framework (Cabinet policy → Commonwealth–State agreements → TGA Plan → AusVaxSafety delivery). This includes reconciling TGA's October 2021 public representation of the Plan as the overarching framework for enhanced monitoring with its October 2025 Senate testimony that monitoring was managed through "day-to-day processes", a description at odds with the formal governance structures and documentation expected under concurrent Commonwealth–State implementation agreements and COVID-19 vaccination program plans.
2. The adequacy of governance, integration and performance monitoring arrangements to ensure that Cabinet-endorsed safety-monitoring commitments for provisionally approved vaccines were demonstrably delivered, including

systematic integration of AusVaxSafety active-surveillance data into TGA signal management and regulatory decision-making.

3. Lessons for future emergency programs, including minimum documentation, integration and verification requirements where provisional approval is granted at scale and enhanced post-market monitoring is a key risk-mitigation measure, so that implementation can be independently assessed against Cabinet-level commitments and regulatory conditions.

During the period when these vaccines remained provisionally approved, millions of Australians received doses under a Cabinet-endorsed promise of enhanced, documented safety monitoring. The core question for public trust is now evidentiary: can clear, documented assurances be given that those commitments were fulfilled as promised? If not, what reforms are necessary before the next public health emergency?

The complete analysis, underlying documentation, and primary sources are permanently available for the Committee's review:

Open-Source Audit & Evidence: <https://github.com/paulrekaris/TGA-COVID19-Vaccine-Safety-Monitoring-Audit>

Permanent Research Archive (DOI): <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.17731054>

I would be happy to provide further information or a briefing if the Committee considers it of assistance.

Paul Rekaris

paulrekaris@gmail.com

Tel: 0419 346 580



webinar-presentation-pharmacovigilance-regulators-perspective.pdf
2608K

Community Affairs, Committee (SEN) <Community.Affairs.Sen@aph.gov.au>

2 March 2026 at 15:40

To: Paul <paulrekaris@gmail.com>, "Cox, Dorinda (Senator)" <Senator.Cox@aph.gov.au>

Cc: "Allman-Payne, Penny (Senator Office)" <Senator.Allman-Payne@aph.gov.au>, "Antic, Alex (Senator)" <Senator.Antic@aph.gov.au>, "Community Affairs, Committee (SEN)" <Community.Affairs.Sen@aph.gov.au>

Good afternoon

At a recent private meeting, the committee considered your correspondence and noted the issues you have raised.

Kind regards,

 Committee Secretary

Senate Standing Committees on Community Affairs | Department of the Senate

www.aph.gov.au/senate



I acknowledge the traditional Custodians of Country throughout Australia and pay my respect to the elders, past and present of all Australia's Indigenous peoples.

From: Paul <paulrekaris@gmail.com>
Sent: Tuesday, 16 December 2025 9:24 AM
To: Cox, Dorinda (Senator) <Senator.Cox@aph.gov.au>
Cc: Allman-Payne, Penny (Senator Office) <Senator.Allman-Payne@aph.gov.au>; Antic, Alex (Senator) <Senator.Antic@aph.gov.au>; Community Affairs, Committee (SEN) <Community.Affairs.Sen@aph.gov.au>
Subject: COVID-19 vaccine safety monitoring commitments – request for committee scrutiny

Dear Senator Cox,

At the Community Affairs Legislation Committee's 9 October 2025 estimates hearing, senior TGA officials described COVID-19 vaccine safety monitoring as being managed through the agency's "day-to-day pharmacovigilance processes" during the TGA's COVID-19 Vaccine Safety Monitoring Plan. Officials were unable to point to any systematic tracking of implementation against the Plan's stated objectives. This characterisation appears difficult to reconcile with the "enhanced" monitoring that was a legal condition of the provisional approval of these vaccines, and with National Cabinet's commitment to active and comprehensive post-market safety monitoring in the [Australian COVID-19 Vaccination Policy](#).

For clarity, this correspondence does not suggest that safety monitoring activities did not occur. Rather, it concerns the absence of verifiable, systematic documentation demonstrating that the COVID-19 Vaccine Safety Monitoring Plan was implemented as a discrete, enhanced framework, as distinct from routine pharmacovigilance activities.

In an October 2021 pharmacovigilance presentation, TGA presented the COVID-19 Vaccine Safety Monitoring Plan (slide 23) as the overarching pharmacovigilance framework aiming to "enhance rapid detection, investigation and response" through five defined key strategies, detailing structured workflows, databases,

communication processes and the Adverse Event Management System. This presentation, used to educate future pharmacy professionals on how the system operated, depicts a formal, documented program – a depiction fundamentally at odds with the October 2025 Senate testimony describing enhanced pharmacovigilance as day-to-day processes. The presentation is publicly available at: <https://www.tga.gov.au/sites/default/files/webinar-presentation-pharmacovigilance-regulators-perspective.pdf> and is attached in this email (**please note copyright notice**).

Subsequently, in decision AICmr54, the Office of the Australian Information Commissioner accepted that TGA could not identify any discrete implementation report for the Safety Monitoring Plan, after OAIC-directed MR22/00538 searches across more than 531 TRIM containers and over 2,200 sampled pages located no Plan-specific implementation or governance records. A later FOI request (25-0166) separately identified 399 Plan-aligned documents using standard classifications (SOPs, protocols, workflows, implementation guidelines), but TGA declined to process them in full, relying on a practical-refusal decision under the Freedom of Information Act 1982 (Cth).

Taken together, the OAIC finding and the 9 October evidence indicate a serious and documented gap between Cabinet-endorsed safety monitoring commitments, the TGA's published Plan, and the evidence required to demonstrate that enhanced monitoring was delivered. This gap pertains to the oversight of approximately 68 million doses administered under provisional approval (around 94% of Australia's COVID-19 vaccine rollout).

This documentation gap stands in stark contrast to the structured governance framework established for the rollout itself. The [Commonwealth–State implementation plans](#), signed in February 2021 concurrently with the TGA's Safety Monitoring Plan, created formal governance structures requiring documented procedures, structured data reporting, and Statements of Assurance under the National Partnership on COVID-19 Response. These arrangements anticipated systematic implementation, defined data flows, and clear escalation pathways for safety-critical issues—not the undocumented, "day-to-day processes" described in recent TGA Senate testimony.

For ease of reference, I have prepared an open-source audit of the Safety Monitoring Plan that summarises the key issues and evidence, including an FAQ addressing common questions about this documentation and implementation gap:

GitHub Repository & FAQ: <https://github.com/paulrekaris/TGA-COVID19-Vaccine-Safety-Monitoring-Audit/blob/main/FAQ.md>

Under the Senate's standing orders, the Committee may examine the performance of departments and agencies. In that context, I am providing this material to assist the Committee in deciding whether further scrutiny is warranted regarding how the TGA and the Department implemented and documented these Cabinet-endorsed safety monitoring commitments.

If the Committee considers further examination appropriate, I respectfully suggest it might consider terms of reference for an inquiry, to examine:

1. Whether the Department of Health and Aged Care and the TGA complied with Commonwealth record-keeping, transparency and accountability obligations in implementing the COVID-19 Vaccine Safety Monitoring Plan within the established multi-tier governance framework (Cabinet policy → Commonwealth–State agreements → TGA Plan → AusVaxSafety delivery). This includes reconciling TGA's October 2021 public representation of the Plan as the overarching framework for enhanced monitoring with its October 2025 Senate testimony that monitoring was managed through “day-to-day processes”, a description at odds with the formal governance structures and documentation expected under concurrent Commonwealth–State implementation agreements and COVID-19 vaccination program plans.
2. The adequacy of governance, integration and performance monitoring arrangements to ensure that Cabinet-endorsed safety-monitoring commitments for provisionally approved vaccines were demonstrably delivered, including systematic integration of AusVaxSafety active-surveillance data into TGA signal management and regulatory decision-making.
3. Lessons for future emergency programs, including minimum documentation, integration and verification requirements where provisional approval is granted at scale and enhanced post-market monitoring is a key risk-mitigation measure, so that implementation can be independently assessed against Cabinet-level commitments and regulatory conditions.

During the period when these vaccines remained provisionally approved, millions of Australians received doses under a Cabinet-endorsed promise of enhanced, documented safety monitoring. The core question for public trust is now evidentiary: can clear, documented assurances be given that those commitments were fulfilled as promised? If not, what reforms are necessary before the next public health emergency?

The complete analysis, underlying documentation, and primary sources are permanently available for the Committee's review:

Open-Source Audit & Evidence: <https://github.com/paulrekaris/TGA-COVID19-Vaccine-Safety-Monitoring-Audit>

Permanent Research Archive (DOI): <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.17731054>

I would be happy to provide further information or a briefing if the Committee considers it of assistance.

Paul Rekaris

paulrekaris@gmail.com

